

Northwind Employee Handbook

This handbook explains how Northwind Traders works: how we protect customer data, how we handle time away from work, and what to do when something goes wrong. It applies to every employee and contractor, and it is reviewed by the operations team every January.

1 Information Security

Every laptop issued by Northwind uses full-disk encryption, and the encryption key is escrowed with the IT department so that a lost device can be recovered. Passwords must be at least fourteen characters long and must never be reused across services. Multi-factor authentication is mandatory for email, source control, and the finance system.

Customer records may only be stored in the approved data warehouse. Copying customer data to a personal device, a personal cloud account, or an unapproved spreadsheet is a disciplinary offence, even when the intent is to work more efficiently. Suspected data exposure must be reported to security@northwind.example within one hour of discovery.

Access to production systems is granted for a maximum of thirty days at a time and is reviewed by a second engineer. Shared accounts are not permitted; every action must be attributable to a named person.

2 Leave and Time Off

Full-time employees accrue twenty-five days of paid annual leave per year, plus public holidays. Up to five unused days may be carried over into the first quarter of the following year; any remaining balance expires on the thirty-first of March. Leave requests of more than ten consecutive working days require approval from a department director.

Parental leave is sixteen weeks at full pay for the primary caregiver and six weeks at full pay for the secondary caregiver, available to employees with at least six months of service. Sick leave does not count against annual leave and requires a medical certificate only after five consecutive days of absence.

3 Expenses

Travel must be booked through the corporate travel portal. Economy class is required for flights under six hours; premium economy is permitted for longer flights. Hotel costs are reimbursed up to the city limits in the table below, and receipts must be submitted within thirty days of the trip ending.

City	Nightly limit
London	GBP 220
New York	USD 310
Singapore	SGD 350

Meals are reimbursed at actual cost up to seventy-five dollars per day. Alcohol is never reimbursable. Corporate cards must not be used for personal purchases, even if the employee intends to repay the amount.

4 Incident Response

When a production incident is declared, the on-call engineer becomes incident commander until they explicitly hand the role to someone else. The commander opens an incident channel, posts a status update every thirty minutes, and decides when customers are notified. Customer notification is required for any incident that exposes customer data or causes more than one hour of unavailability.

Within five working days of resolution, the commander publishes a blameless post-incident review describing the timeline, the contributing factors, and the follow-up actions with named owners and due dates. Follow-up actions are tracked in the reliability backlog and reviewed weekly until every one is closed.